

Pre-Flight Privacy Checklist

Documentary & News Footage

Complete this checklist before every drone flight for journalism, current affairs & public interest footage.

Job Details

OPERATOR NAME

DATE OF FLIGHT

STORY / ASSIGNMENT TITLE

NEWS OUTLET / BROADCASTER

LICENCE / RPA REG NO.

WEATHER CONDITIONS

1 — Legal Basis & Public Interest Justification

- ☐ **Public interest justification documented for this assignment**
Editorial decision recorded in writing; footage directly supports the news or documentary story.
- ☐ **Minimum necessary data principle applied to flight plan**
Flight scope limited to what is reasonably necessary; no speculative wide-area surveillance.
- ☐ **Legal advice sought if covering active legal proceedings or crime scenes**
Court orders, suppression orders or police exclusion zones reviewed before flight.
- ☐ **Privacy Act exemption (journalism) assessed and documented**
Operator satisfied that journalistic exemption under the Privacy Act applies to this assignment.
- ☐ **Editorial sign-off obtained from news director / executive producer**
Senior editorial approval on record before drone is deployed.
- ☐ **Subjects of investigation notified where safe and practicable**
Right of reply or notification given unless doing so would compromise safety or story integrity.

2 — No-Fly Zones & Airspace

- ☐ **Airspace checked via CASA tool (Airshare / OneSky)**
No restricted, prohibited or controlled airspace within planned flight area.
- ☐ **NOTAM reviewed for flight date and time**
No active NOTAMs affecting the site.
- ☐ **Proximity to aerodromes confirmed**
5.5 km radius from controlled aerodromes checked; CASA authorisation obtained if required.
- ☐ **Emergency service operations in the area checked**
Police, fire or ambulance activity confirmed not to conflict with planned flight zone.
- ☐ **Flight within visual line of sight (VLOS) or BVLOS approval held**
VLOS maintained at all times or BVLOS approval from CASA confirmed in writing.
- ☐ **Operating height at or below 120 m AGL (or approved altitude)**
Maximum planned altitude confirmed; any exemption documented.

3 — Privacy Risk Assessment

- ☐ **Identifiable individuals in footage assessed against public interest test**
Each person captured considered: are they a public figure acting in public capacity?
- ☐ **Private individuals captured only where incidental or essential to the story**
No gratuitous or voyeuristic footage of private individuals; minimum capture principle applied.
- ☐ **Sensitive locations assessed (private residences, hospitals, schools, refuges)**
Heightened justification required; footage of sensitive sites reviewed before broadcast.
- ☐ **Children or vulnerable persons present — additional safeguards applied**
Faces of minors and vulnerable adults not broadcast without guardian consent.
- ☐ **Protests, vigils or gatherings — participant privacy considered**
Political or religious assembly footage handled with care; participant identities protected unless public figure.
- ☐ **Flight path designed to capture only what is necessary for the story**
No wide-area surveillance beyond the editorial scope of the assignment.

4 — Data Collection Limits

- ☐ **Footage limited to the editorial scope of the assignment**
Operator and journalist briefed; no incidental filming of unrelated persons or properties.
- ☐ **Live broadcast reviewed by producer before transmission**
No live aerial feed transmitted without editorial oversight; delay buffer used where possible.
- ☐ **Audio recording disclosed or disabled**
Onboard microphone off or all relevant parties informed of audio capture.
- ☐ **Facial recognition or metadata tagging not applied without editorial approval**
No automated identification of individuals applied to raw footage without documented sign-off.
- ☐ **Enhanced sensors (thermal, multispectral) not deployed without justification**
Use of non-standard sensors documented; proportionality to public interest story confirmed.

5 — Data Handling & Storage

- ☐ **SD card / storage media is blank before flight**
No residual footage from previous assignments on recording media.
- ☐ **Footage transferred to encrypted newsroom / production storage within 24 hours**
AES-256 encrypted drive or approved broadcast storage with access controls.
- ☐ **Unbroadcast footage retained securely and access restricted**
Raw rushes not shared externally; access log maintained for legal hold purposes.
- ☐ **Retention schedule complies with outlet policy and legal obligations**
Footage held for minimum period required by editorial policy or litigation hold; then deleted.
- ☐ **Footage not supplied to third parties (police, government) without legal basis**
Any request for footage reviewed by legal counsel before compliance; warrant required.

6 — Equipment Pre-Flight Check

- ☐ **RPA registration / markings current and visible**
- ☐ **Battery charged at or above 80%; spare batteries checked**
- ☐ **Propellers inspected — no cracks or chips**
- ☐ **Return-to-home altitude set above tallest obstacle at location**
- ☐ **Gimbal and camera calibrated**
- ☐ **Remote ID broadcasting confirmed (if required)**
- ☐ **Journalist / reporter briefed on drone flight windows and safety exclusion zone**

7 — Post-Flight Actions

- ☐ **Footage reviewed for unintended sensitive personal data capture**
Flag footage of private individuals, children or sensitive locations; refer to editor before use.
- ☐ **Complaints or objections from subjects logged and escalated**
Any objections raised during or after flight recorded and referred to editorial and legal teams.
- ☐ **Incident log updated if any airspace, safety or privacy issue arose**
Record near-misses, complaints or unplanned captures; notify outlet's legal team if required.
- ☐ **Completed checklist retained and copy provided to news director**
Signed copy held by operator for minimum 7 years; outlet retains copy per editorial policy.

Operator Sign-Off

By signing below I confirm all checklist items have been reviewed and completed to the best of my knowledge.